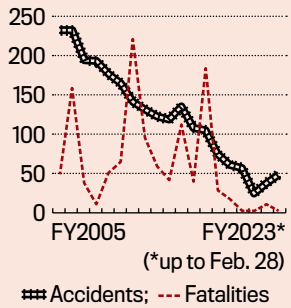


TRAIN ACCIDENTS AND PASSENGER FATALITIES

Balasore's death toll of 288 alone is higher than that recorded throughout any year since FY2005. Barring an uptick in FY2023, the no. of train accidents has been on a decline in recent years



KEY INITIATIVES TO MAKE TRAINS SAFE

Rashtriya Rail Sanraksha Kosh

- Created in 2017-18 for five years with annual contribution of Rs 20,000 cr
- To fund the replacement/ renewal/ upgradation of critical safety assets
- Extended for another five years with a total provision of Rs 45,000 crore

KAVACH

- An indigenous automatic train protection system
- Prevents collision, controls overspeeding and aids the loco pilot to avoid passing a signal at danger
- Implemented on 1,200 km of South Central Railway. To be extended to 3,009 km of Delhi-Mumbai and Delhi-Howrah corridors by 2024

Electronic Interlocking

- Route can be set and monitored remotely, enhances safety by reducing manual intervention
- Has replaced the old mechanical, relay-based interlocking at 2,521 stations since 2014-15

Ultrasonic Flaw Detection

- Testing of rails to detect flaws and ensure timely removal of defective rails; introduced across the Indian Railways

There is no denying, though, that manpower and maintenance remain the weak links in the chain of railway operations. Loco pilots do long stretches of 12 or more hours. On May 17, the Railway Board pulled up the South East Central Railway (SECR), after it found that 36 per cent of its crew had been working for 12+ hours a day since March. The latest CAG report also refers to the skill deficit among the contractual workers and the poor follow-up training of staff. It recommended, among other things, that running duty hours and total duty hours be eight hours and 11 hours, respectively, and apply to all running staff, including loco pilots, motormen and guards. Shifts longer than 12 hours are especially dangerous for crew directly involved in station, track and rolling stock operations. Yet, the mandated hours are honoured more in the breach.

Maintenance of track, signalling and rolling stock, therefore, have to be overwhelming priorities. The obsession with punctuality and completing maintenance tasks within the available time can become a danger. "The Bahanaga Bazar accident took place on one of the busiest routes of the railways, where the line capacity utilisation was more than 100 per cent. On such busy routes, hardly any time is given to the staff to carry out maintenance or repairs," says a former director-general of the Indian Railways Institute of Signal Engineering and Telecommunications, Secunderabad, who did not wish to be named.

Staff shortage is another serious concern, and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge in a letter to the prime minister pointed out that there are 300,000 posts lying vacant in the Indian Railways. Many of these are in the safety category. "Several key positions such as locomotive pilots and track maintainers are vacant," confirms B. Vinod Kumar, vice-chairperson, Telangana Planning Board and former member of the parliamentary committee on railways. "There is also an acute shortage of skilled security personnel at electric traction substations nationwide, with over 30,000 vacancies." The lack of manpower compromises the ability to conduct regular checks, leading to potential safety hazards. Staff scarcity also leads to low response time during emergencies, disrupting train services. Senior railways officials disagree, saying they have added almost half a million people to their staff in the past nine years and the growing automation of services is meant to reduce staff, not augment it.

Safety, though, must remain top priority. Says a top expert, "The first lesson of the crash is, don't hide your failures." The current culture of hauling up people for failures, he says, while not bad in itself, leads to underreporting of such incidents. In a LinkedIn blog, Ashwani Lohani, a former Railway Board chairman, writes, "While it is so right to pin individual lapses, if the number of cases of such lapses becomes a matter of concern, it should be evident that the problem is either systemic or related to the morale and working environment at functional levels." The Coromandel Crash, then, is a wake-up call to ensure all these issues are resolved. And at the earliest. ■

–*with* Pradip R. Sagar